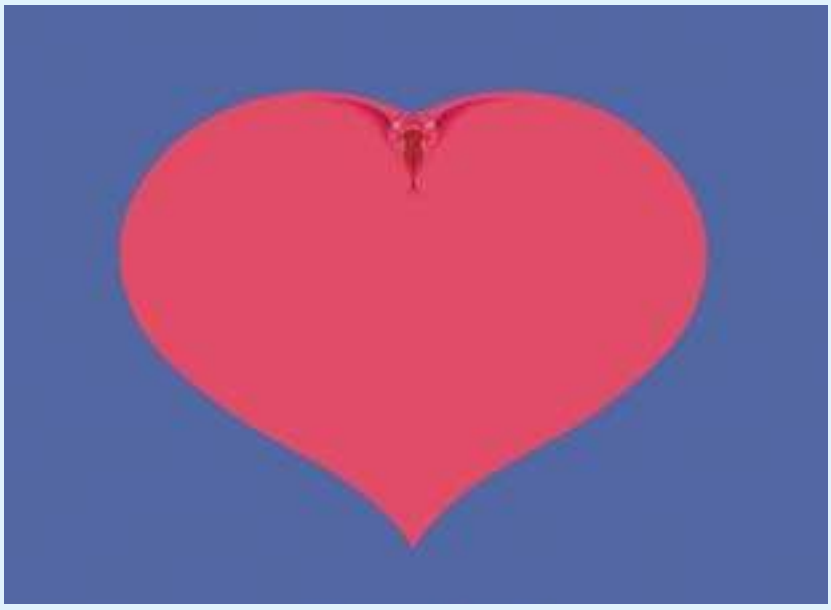


Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

▶ WEST BENGAL

LOVE, LOOT, LOGOUT

The heart wins over mind—and money—as a new online fraud targets women with fake matrimonial profiles

By **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar**

IT COULD SCREAM A DIME NOVEL...'a chilling saga of deception, trust and heartbreak'. Or think of it as a runaway marriage between two eminently compatible forms of online behaviour: the pursuit of love, and of money. The cybercrime sleuths of Hooghly Rural Police first thought it was a routine case of online fraud. But they saw it had a pattern all its own: the victims missed as many heartbeats as they did hard dough. The first complainant, a 29-year-old woman from Singur, had been duped of Rs 43 lakh—by a man she met on a matrimonial website.

He called himself Anupam Roy, supposedly a wealthy rice mill owner from Bardhaman. The online acquaintance began last December: innocent at first, perhaps even hopeful, like many such modern-day matches.

Takeaways

- **A Singur woman lost Rs 43 lakh to a fake groom in a web of emotional deceit**
- **Police uncover a Rs 3 cr. racket, putting a question mark on matrimony websites**

On January 13, 'Anupam' reached out with a plea. His bank account, he said, had been frozen due to some tax complications. Could she please help? The woman's family, especially her mother and grandmother, saw this as a test of goodwill—and sent him money. A few days later, 'Anupam' sent them an image of a bank deposit slip, claiming he had returned Rs 9 lakh. It bore a State Bank of India seal from the Kable branch in Arambagh, Hooghly—a detail that lent false authenticity. He told them the amount would reflect once his account was restored. But it never did.

THE PLOT THICKENS

From then on, it was a downward spiral. The man kept asking for money. Each time, the mother obliged. The victim herself had grown suspicious and asked her mother to stop. "She'd say he's an orphan and we should help," she recalled. "But every time I tried to call him on video, he would say he was in a poor network area."

By May, his matrimony profile had vanished, his number went unreachable, and the family realised they had been conned. In five months of interaction, they had never met him—not even on a video call. On May 27, the woman finally knocked on the doors of the law. The sleuth work that followed was swift. On July 3, police arrested Avishek Roy, a 32-year-old model, whose bank account was one of the five used to receive the money. Within a week, police arrested Zahir Abbas (42); three months later, on October 14, they got to the mastermind—Zamir Abbas (31), hiding at a beach resort in Mandarmani, Purba Medinipur.

The Abbas brothers were seasoned operators. Using stolen photos and videos of a South Indian model, they created fake matrimonial profiles that projected wealth, decency and emotional warmth. The mothers, it seems, fell for 'him' too—those desperate to see their daughters married. "It was emotional manipulation more than cyber fraud," says a cop.

The gang had duped at least 20 women—from Bardhaman, Howrah, Tarakeswar, even Delhi—snaffling over Rs 3 crore. Each script was the same: love, loot and logout. The case raises questions: why are matrimony websites not mandated to verify user identities? "Anyone can create a profile on these websites. Verification should be mandatory," says Kamanasish Sen, SP, Hooghly Rural. Especially since the internet may have changed how we find love, not how love can blind us. ■